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That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, sunny, little wind, high 49.
Tonight, clear, low 36, temperatures
below freezing in the suburbs. **To-
morrow**, partly cloudy, warmer; high
54. Weather map is on Page B10.

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How Trump Took the U.S. To War With Iran

TIERNEY L. CROSS/THE NEW YORK TIMES



ERIC LEE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

GEN. DAN CAINE The chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff said that Israel was over-selling its plans for the war.



TIERNEY L. CROSS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

MARCO RUBIO The secretary of state was against the U.S. entering a war if the goal was regime change or an uprising.



ERIC LEE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

PETE HEGSETH The defense secretary favored the war, arguing action would have to be taken in Iran eventually.



TIERNEY L. CROSS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

JD VANCE The vice president was the stark exception inside the White House in his opposition to a full-scale war.

From Netanyahu’s Hard Sell to Inner-Circle Talks That Greenlit Attack

By JONATHAN SWAN and MAGGIE HABERMAN

The black S.U.V. carrying Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu arrived at the White House just before 11 a.m. on Feb. 11. The Israeli leader, who had been pressing for months for the United States to agree to a major assault on Iran, was whisked inside with little ceremony, out of view of reporters, primed for one of the most high-stakes moments in his long career.

U.S. and Israeli officials gathered first in the Cabinet Room, adjacent to the Oval Office. Then Mr. Netanyahu headed downstairs for

the main event: a highly classified presentation on Iran for President Trump and his team in the White House Situation Room, which was rarely used for in-person meetings with foreign leaders.

Mr. Trump sat down, but not in his usual position at the head of the room’s mahogany conference table. Instead, the president took a seat on one side, facing the large screens mounted along the wall. Mr. Netanyahu sat on the other side, directly opposite the president.

Appearing on the screen behind the prime minister was David Barnea, the director of Mossad, Israel’s foreign intelligence agency,

as well as Israeli military officials. Arrayed visually behind Mr. Netanyahu, they created the image of a wartime leader surrounded by his team.

Susie Wiles, the White House chief of staff, sat at the far end of the table. Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who doubled as the national security adviser, had taken his regular seat. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, who generally sat together in such settings, were on one side; joining them was John Ratcliffe, the C.I.A. director. Jared Kushner, the president’s son-in-law, and Steve Witkoff, Mr.

Trump’s special envoy, who had been negotiating with the Iranians, rounded out the main group.

The gathering had been kept deliberately small to guard against leaks. Other top cabinet secretaries had no idea it was happening. Also absent was the vice president. JD Vance was in Azerbaijan, and the meeting had been scheduled on such short notice that he was unable to make it back in time.

The presentation that Mr. Netanyahu would make over the next hour would be pivotal in setting the United States and Israel on the path toward a major armed con-

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Paris’s Catacombs Are Brighter. They’ll Still Chill Your Bones.

By ANA CASTELAIN

PARIS — For more than two centuries, tourists have descended beneath the streets of Paris to visit the catacombs, a dank and macabre labyrinth filled with the remains of up to six million Parisians. From floor to ceiling, they are lined with bones, femur by femur, skull by skull, that draw 600,000 visitors a year to the dimly lit tunnels.

Parts of those gloomy passages have now been given a much-needed face-lift.

Over the past five months, architects, designers, technicians and masons have been renovating this vast tomb — installing new

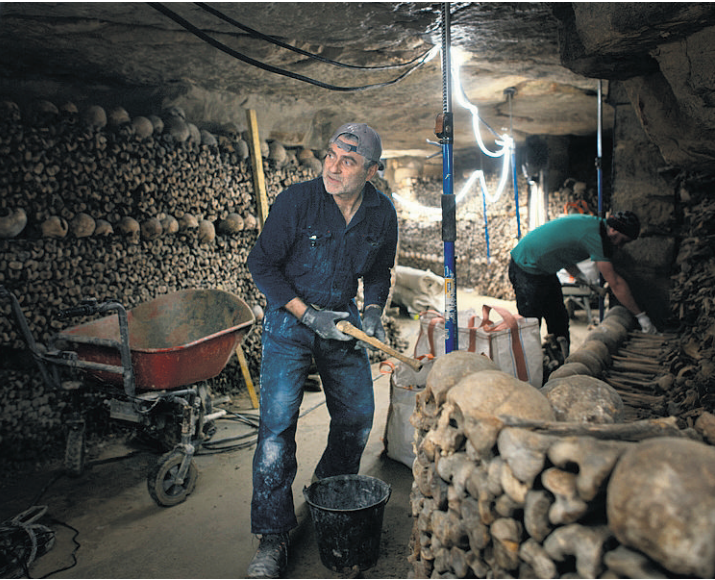
lighting and ventilation systems, restoring the bone walls and preparing new audio guides. Some elements of the labyrinth, previously unlit, will now be visible to visitors.

The goal, curators say, is to preserve the site and make it more accessible while still maintaining its somber, spooky appeal.

“The goal isn’t to turn it into Disneyland,” said Isabelle Knafou, the catacombs’ administrator.

The labyrinth extends for hundreds of miles, and the mile-long section that the public can visit

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DMITRY KOSTYUKOV FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

“It puts us back in our place as mortals,” the stonemason Florent Bastaroli said of the ossuary, first opened to the public in 1809.

CEASE-FIRE CALLED AFTER TENSE DAY THREATENING IRAN

Trump Veers From ‘Civilization Will Die’ to Agreeing to Two-Week Pause

This article is by Tyler Pager, Farnaz Fassihi, Julian E. Barnes, Ronen Bergman and Michael Levenson.

WASHINGTON — President Trump said on Tuesday evening that he had agreed to a two-week cease-fire with Iran, backing away from an apocalyptic threat he had issued only hours earlier that a “whole civilization will die tonight” if Iran did not reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Mr. Trump said the cease-fire was “subject to the Islamic Republic of Iran agreeing to the COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE, and SAFE OPENING of the Strait of Hormuz.” Several Iranian officials who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss diplomacy said that Iran had agreed to the deal, which Pakistan negotiated.

Mr. Trump said he had agreed to a cease-fire because the United States had “met and exceeded” its military objectives in the bombing campaign and was “very far along” in efforts to reach a long-term peace deal with Iran.

The president posted his statement on social media just over an hour before his deadline of 8 p.m. Eastern time for Iran to allow unimpeded shipping through the strait or face devastating attacks on its bridges and power plants.

The announcement came after the prime minister of Pakistan, Shehbaz Sharif, said on social media that diplomatic efforts were “progressing steadily, strongly and powerfully with the potential to lead to substantive results.” Mr. Sharif asked Mr. Trump to extend his deadline by two weeks. He also asked Iran to open the strait during the two-week period and called on both sides to observe a cease-fire during that time.

There was no immediate word from Israel about whether it

would abide by the cease-fire. While a two-week pause would not end the war, it buys time for the Trump administration and Iran to work out a longer-term agreement to end the conflict, which has killed thousands of people in Iran over more than a month.

In the hours before Mr. Trump’s deadline, Iranians were bracing for even more devastating American strikes. Striking civilian infra-



ARASH KHAMOOSHI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Debris at Sharif University of Technology in Tehran after it was hit in a strike on Monday.

structure could be a war crime under international law, legal experts say — but Mr. Trump had appeared unconcerned.

“A whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again,” the American president wrote on social media on Tuesday, though he said he hoped “maybe something revolutionarily wonderful can happen,” given the changes in Iranian leadership since the war began.

“We will find out tonight, one of the most important moments in

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Cutting Deals With Autocrats On Deportation

This article is by Eileen Sullivan, Hamed Aleaziz, Megha Rajagopalan and Pranav Baskar.

As President Trump searches the world for countries willing to accept thousands of migrants deported from the United States, he is finding that some of the most receptive leaders are strongmen, autocrats and human rights abusers.

American diplomats are under such pressure from the White House to cut deals that they have put nearly everything on the negotiating table, records show: The United States will pay foreign security forces, ease visa restrictions or tariffs, finance public health services and even reconsider a country’s placement on U.S. watch lists.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio’s office, in a February cable seen by The New York Times, coached diplomats on how to extract initial offers.

“If you are willing to take more individuals, then we can potentially provide more support,” was one suggested line. “Without making any promises, what do you have in mind?” was another.

The cable put no constraints on whom the United States could negotiate with. Regarding a list of unspecified “Countries of Concern,” American diplomats were told that accepting migrants “can help a country improve its rela-

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Ukraine Moves To Deny Russia An Oil Windfall

By CONSTANT MÉHEUT

KYIV, Ukraine — Aerial drone attacks forcing a major Russian oil terminal to halt operations. Sea drones damaging tankers linked to Moscow. Strikes igniting refineries across western Russia.

As Moscow benefits from soaring oil prices and an easing of U.S. sanctions as a result of the war in Iran, Ukraine is trying to offset the windfall by escalating strikes on Russian oil assets. Experts describe a campaign unprecedented in scale, with Ukraine claiming responsibility for 10 attacks last month, though the true number is probably higher.

The most significant strikes have hit Russia’s Baltic ports of Ust-Luga and Primorsk, which handle roughly 40 percent of the country’s seaborne crude exports. Local authorities reported damage at both ports, and the number of tankers loading oil there has plummeted, according to an analysis of trading activity by Bloomberg.

Kyiv’s calculation is simple: Every barrel of Russian oil that cannot be exported is money Moscow cannot spend on war. In a statement, Ukraine’s Defense Ministry described “coordinated precision strikes” aimed at depriving the Kremlin of “billions of dollars that are directly converted into missiles and ammunition.”

The reality is more compli-

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SPORTS B6-10

Belgians Investigate Cyclists

Dozens of riders, including the winner, ran a red light at a railway crossing during the Tour of Flanders. PAGE B10

Reversing Michigan’s Fortunes

As players become more transient in the N.I.L. era, coaches like Dusty May are often the main attraction. PAGE B6



NATIONAL A13-20

An ICE Account Falls Apart

Video footage of a shooting in Minneapolis is raising questions about why prosecutors did not review it until weeks after bringing charges. PAGE A18

‘Copy, Moon Joy’

Astronauts normally known for staid professionalism are waxing expressive about their historic lunar flyby on the NASA mission Artemis II. PAGE A14

Enrollment Dip Shakes College

Lewis University, which was remade by an influx of international students, is struggling amid the Trump administration’s curbs on visa approvals. PAGE A13

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Rethinking Risks of Nuclear

Shocks to natural gas supplies are spurring countries in Asia and elsewhere to reconsider their rejection of nuclear energy. PAGE B1

An A.I. Code Overload

Companies are finding that A.I. tools can greatly accelerate code production. But many find it is more than they can keep up with. PAGE B1

A Bid to Buy Universal Music

The \$64 billion deal pitched by the hedge fund manager Bill Ackman would need to pass muster with the label’s shareholders. PAGE B1

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Black Music’s Long Journey

The bassist Melvin Gibbs has worked to map the route that birthed nearly all of American popular music. PAGE C1

Exploring the Unbearable

“Innocence,” a powerful depiction of mass violence and its aftermath, has arrived at the Met Opera. PAGE C1



FOOD D1-8

The Real Meat of the Matter

Once maligned as a culprit in an epidemic of cardiovascular disease, beef is now seen by some as a cure-all. PAGE D1

A New Type of Influencing

Audiences and restaurant owners have been souring on predictable voice-overs and pay-for-play reviews. PAGE D1

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Dana Milbank

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